

On Modesty — For Adult Society

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Within the world of Torah, many fierce debates rage over the subject of modesty (tzniut). Every religious sub-community, one might say, shapes the relations between women and men in a way distinct from its neighbors, generally in accordance with its broader religious outlook — to the point that the question of separation and mixing, the most prominent categories for characterizing a society's conception of modesty, has become a kind of sociological litmus test for mapping and surveying the religious sectors and the ideological differences among them. Although it is customary to polarize disputes in order to sharpen them, it is important to stress the edges of the discussion: on the one hand, all Torah positions agree that there is some minimal degree of interface between women and men that is legitimate simply as part of the constraints of life; and on the other hand, all Torah positions agree that a certain degree of distance between women and men is required, and that there are settings in which the fitting conduct is separate. The main disagreements about separation cut across areas that are not one-dimensional — weddings and celebrations, social events, parent-teacher meetings, family outings, family activity groups, the extended-family Shabbat table, and so on. Contrary to the common terminology, which frames the dispute as being about "mixed society or separate society," this is not a binary question at all, but a very wide spectrum of small questions and different possibilities, all spread along an axis whose directions are separation and mixing but whose boundaries lie somewhere in a defined region.[1] Of course, the specific position of each society and each ideology on this axis — which is not necessarily fully one-dimensional — is only a sign and expression of its particular conception of modesty, of its answer to the question of what the character and essence of modesty actually is. Accordingly, the real differences between the ideologies lie on this deeper, essential plane, except that it is harder to formulate precisely, distinctly and in a way that invites confrontation, and so it does not stand at the forefront of the publicized polemic.

In the essay before you I try to deal mainly with the basic plane of the essence of the virtue of modesty. The picture I will sketch touches on modesty from the private point of view, as a virtue of the individual soul. Beyond the fact that this is, in my opinion, the more basic question, prior in essential-logical terms, there is a further reason for this approach: it is true that society is shaped in light of the inner conceptions of the people who belong to it, but since society is also heterogeneous, it is quite likely that we will find ourselves in a society whose existing behavioral code we do not one-hundred-percent identify with. In other words — after all the arguments about the proper shape of society, there is a good chance that, in practice, in our personal lives, we will have to cope with and live within an environment in which social modesty is not to our taste. Focusing on the "revealed," public-social plane of the discussion misses the question of personal improvement, of the correct personal struggle and approach, of modesty as a virtue of the soul that must be cultivated

and strengthened, that we carry with us wherever we go — even in a society that is too mixed for our taste.[2] I will deal, then, with the virtue of personal modesty specifically as it ought to find expression in mixed social situations.[3]

Since most rabbinic and public engagement with this subject focuses on the sphere of educational frameworks,[4] and especially on youth society, it is easier to illustrate the different spiritual directions through the prism of an educational approach. One can speak of three general models of modesty active in our current educational and public arena, among which there are further approaches and nuances. They can be characterized by the place in the soul on which they rely: modesty founded on shame, modesty founded on recoil, and modesty founded on normalization.

Education toward modesty founded on shame is common in places where society is genuinely quite separate, and where contact between children and adolescents and members of the opposite sex is indeed an unusual occurrence. The foundations of this kind of modesty education are foreignness and a lack of belonging to the world of the opposite sex. This is, in essence, a continuation and development of childhood shame into the sphere of adolescence — the shame that comes from difference, the tension it creates, and the inability or unwillingness to cope with it. I am ashamed around girls,[5] and so I do not draw close to them; I have nothing in common with them; meeting them may cause me excitement and embarrassment that I do not want to stand before.

The advantage of this approach is its naturalness — the modesty arises from a straightforward, authentic feeling, and is not imposed on the person as a measure pressing on him from without. The problem lies in the fact that this "infantile," childish measure of shame does not suit the psychic order of the mature adult. The mature adult must overcome embarrassment not through flight and self-alienation, and his consciousness must be open to accepting his own selfhood also on its sexual and romantic sides, and, accordingly, to accepting the other as well, who brings with him difference and a sense of tension.[6]

The second educational model is the one that uses recoil from the forbidden in order to bring about distance between boys and girls — first actual distance, and then psychic distance. This is a modesty whose source is fear of sin, fear itself. Mixed situations are perceived as situations bearing a live possibility of a breach of halakha, of excessive closeness, of licentiousness and of sexual thoughts. The problem here stands out in the intensification of this measure among those who cultivate it, to the point where an encounter with the opposite sex arouses in them feelings of dread and apprehension, and associations of temptation and testing. The psychic distance sought, explicitly, by this model can, in extreme cases, deteriorate into revulsion and even disgust. The language of modesty that appeals to the fear-chambers of the heart deteriorates into a demonic image of woman, and loads our relation to her with sexual context and wariness of her. The burden of dangerous sexual potential that this religious language has created for the encounter between the sexes is not natural to us, and it is precisely the apprehension that floods the consciousness with dark feelings. We would have had the capacity to relate, on a basic level, with a warm countenance to every person, to meet through the simple shared humanity of

both sides, without bringing the subject of sexuality and forbidden thoughts to mind at all. It is precisely the attempt to stress and warn us against every minimal closeness, precisely the tendency to attribute significance to every mixed occasion and to make us recoil and distance ourselves from it — these are what create demons of immodesty in a place where there was normalcy and healthy simplicity.

For example, a halakhic ruling that forbids a situation in which a woman speaks in front of men, on the grounds of "concern for improper thoughts," is problematic not only because it fails to correctly reflect our social reality, but also because of its consequences. Such a ruling raises into the air a hypothetical scenario in which a healthy person who sees a woman and converses with her is dragged into sexual thoughts — a hypothetical scenario I doubt exists as a matter of course in any other mixed society.[7]

If the first two models are embraced mainly by those who lean, generally, toward separation, then the common line of thought among opponents of this approach is that modesty results from behavior that is as naturally normal as possible, even within mixed society. As an opposite direction of reading to the modesty of shame and of fear, they advocate a normalization of the mixed reality — that is, a demonstrative refusal to relate to the fact of sexual mixing as something special that arouses or requires a different psychic approach. Their conclusion is that true modesty is born precisely of ignoring the fact that society is mixed, and of maximal equation, even if within halakhic bounds, of the norms of behavior in mixed society with those in a separate, single-sex society.

This too is a mistake. One can discern, I believe, a certain kind of special energy present in the dynamic of mixed society — extra vitality, extra psychic alertness. At times we are busy denying the fact that there is a difference between the experience of a separate society and that of a mixed society — a difference expressed, for instance, in the fact that in a mixed environment we feel somewhat more tense, we are less relaxed and more concerned about our image and how we present ourselves, the social-psychic ferment is greater, and so on. It seems to me that the source of this denial is the feeling that this very distinctiveness harbors within it a lack of modesty. In truth, failing to attend to this distinctive atmosphere is itself immodest, and this challenge is precisely the task that falls to the virtue of modesty.

What, then, is this modesty that we seek? In what does it find expression, and what is its effect on the being of mixed society and on the soul of the individual? How shall we find what modesty demands of us?

The Halakhic Foundations

The first, basic step is to adopt the three distinct halakhic subjects of modesty in society, each of which has an initial, formal-legal circle that is not open to discussion, and wider circles, which are attained by seeking out the halakhic essence and value and internalizing them, rather than merely applying the practical instruction of the "dry law":

1. Proper, modest dress according to halakha, for girls and for boys alike. This subject was already expanded by our Sages, in their prohibiting the wearing of red (even though this involves no exposure of the body). The essence here is fairly clear — to purify the social space of attempts at seduction and enticement, and to root out the tendency to arouse physical sexual attraction.

2. The prohibition of touch. In this domain I also include the hearing of a woman's singing voice, which our Sages considered a kind of quasi-physical closeness, as well as the prohibition on sexual gazing. In its wider circle, this concerns avoiding mixed physical situations: dance, sport, and any setting in which the body is placed as a central presence.

3. The prohibition of seclusion (yichud). According to some of the early authorities, the Torah source of this prohibition is "you shall not come near to uncover nakedness" — that is, even a closeness that involves no physical contact at all can constitute a forbidden excessive closeness. From this, the principle expands into a prohibition on intimacy of any kind with a woman forbidden to you. The concept of intimacy encompasses various domains within its scope: engagement with physical matters, situations with a context of bonding and connection, and the sharing of personal psychic depths. This expansion is highly significant, and it is what ties romance to modesty — even a platonic bond that is closely intimate is problematic from the standpoint of modesty, if it is not directed toward a commitment within the covenant of marriage.

The fourth subject about which halakha warned in describing modesty is levity (kalut rosh). Here too, in its basic circle, this concerns frivolity and levity that lead a person to sexual immorality,[8] which can be described as unrestrained wildness and dissoluteness. But surely the concept must be broadened, and we must be aware that in mixed society there is a further demand for caution against levity, against an atmosphere that is too loose and too exuberant, even one that is not close to sexual deterioration. In levity itself there is a certain self-exposure and an outburst toward the other, a certain kind of removal of barriers and blurring of boundaries — matters that are problematic mainly in a place where men and women are together. Here, setting the proper boundary is especially difficult, since surely the halakhic intent is not to turn the mixed situation into a place of "gravity" (koved rosh) in the fullest sense of the word. Gravity is a psychic state that halakha associates with being present in the Temple, the synagogue or the cemetery — places that undoubtedly represent a departure from normal, healthy life and require behavior that expresses this. It seems that between levity and gravity lies a very broad domain that is not fully defined, and cannot be fully defined. We will learn to recognize the forbidden levity, and the place where the fine inner boundary is crossed between a warm countenance, health and joy, on the one hand, and a psychic crossing of boundaries, on the other, only after we internalize the essence of the modesty that is sought.

Toward the Root of the Matter

The more advanced step in modesty, after we have established and reinforced the normative foundations, confronts directly the very experience of society's mixedness. To do

so we must ask — what is the source of the "vitality" and the "extra excitement" of our mixed society? What is the psychic "component" that changes the single-sex social experience into that of mixed society?

Some have wished to argue that this is a matter of sexual tension, but in my opinion using this term in its ordinary sense is an exaggeration that denies the reality and the simple, sane and healthy experience of existence of one who lives in such a society. "Sexual tension" is a term used to describe a sensory state, a physical or near-physical sensation. By contrast, when I speak of the "added vitality" or of the somewhat different emotional climate of the mixed situation, I am speaking of something far more subtle, a fine sensation, a small emotional shade of difference. The energy is not sexual, it does not entail any physiological responses, and normally the mind does not go in these directions at all. On the other hand, this is certainly connected to the difference between the sexes — for this is, after all, an experience different from that of a single-sex society.

In my sense, a basic component of this ferment unique to mixed groups is the theoretical possibility of forming a romantic bond. This is a result of affection, which naturally develops between different people in mixed society. Being together often causes us to examine our connection to this or that young woman — not necessarily a serious examination, certainly not necessarily actual falling in love, but a thought that opens up from the very existence of the open option. Each woman is a potential partner for forming companionship and love, an intimate bond. This potential possibility causes this subject to exist, when we are in a mixed environment, somewhere in the psychic atmosphere or in some subconscious layer, and at times it also surfaces in our thoughts.

From here arises the deep lack of modesty that can exist in mixed society.[9] The main problem is when the romantic subject repeatedly floods consciousness (whether personal or collective) where there is no need for it, and even more so when the social ferment centers on this very matter. This is a lack of modesty embodied in a flirtatious quality, and in the fact that social feeling becomes entangled with the deepest, most inward foundations of the soul, with the intimate domain. In this situation there is a violation of two foundations of modesty — the foundation of privacy and the foundation of coupledness. Intimacy, love and romance must be bound both to the private domain and to marital fidelity and exclusivity, and must not constitute permanent components of the social encounter.

The description I have given so far sounds suited mainly to a mixed society of singles, and not to one of married couples. Indeed, there are broad and essential differences in the character of these two kinds of society, and a formulation that focuses on the ferment born of the open romantic option fits the society of singles far more than that of married couples. Since betraying one's spouse in marriage — even of the merely platonic kind — is a grave and set-apart taboo in the society in which we live, it is hard to accept talk of a psychic stir caused by awareness of the possibility of slipping into it. Nevertheless, and after accepting this necessary qualification, the inner point of the matter remains valid and applicable to the society of married couples as well. The romantic-sexual option is something whose existence is a real fact on the plane of actual reality. It is true that, by force of our culture

and values, we can decree "taboo" prohibitions so absolute in our eyes that we genuinely feel as though the possibility of transgressing them does not exist for us at all — but there remains some foundational layer in which the pre-cultural state persists, an unprocessed, uncultured layer of the soul. Not necessarily one that reaches the threshold of conscious awareness; and yet, it can murmur within, ferment, and move us in the directions it strives toward. Monogamy is, apparently, not a natural human inclination, certainly not in an absolute sense. Even if it has long been well imprinted in our psychic makeup, there is no doubt that, alongside it, other forces stir as well, and we have the capacity to feel attraction, charm and falling in love toward another person in parallel. This capacity gives rise in us to a tendency, a driving force, an inner impulse, to seek romantic excitement wherever we turn, even when these are successfully and completely repressed.

Adam and Ish

In order to sharpen this, let me describe the matter in typological terms: between the two creation stories that appear in the Torah (chapters 1 and 2 of Genesis) there are many differences. One of the most prominent is the gap in the description of sexual distinction. In chapter 1, the fact that humankind is made up of "male and female" carries no significance whatsoever, beyond the shared capacity to bear young, as with all animals. The male and the female do not appear as two distinct entities — both are created together in the image of God, both are blessed with the blessing "be fruitful and multiply and fill the earth and subdue it," and both are called by a single name — Adam (humankind). By contrast, in chapter 2 the story is entirely different: there is an "ish" (man) and there is an "isha" (woman), and it concerns two thoroughly distinct creatures. Only the ish and the isha of chapter 2 arrive at the formation of a coupled bond ("and he shall cleave to his wife"), and this bond is described as an alternative to existential loneliness ("it is not good for the human to be alone").

From this we learn that there is a certain duality in the human figure — each of us is both "adam" and "ish" or "isha." There is a general facet of our personality that is shared and human, devoid of gender and of any distinction between male and female — this is the "adam" side within us, the side of common humanity. Alongside it, we are also "ish"/"isha," bearers of personality traits unique to our gender, and bearers of a longing to bond with, and cleave to, the opposite sex.

Mixed community is founded, from the outset, on our "adam" side; within it we relate to women and men with equality and without special distinction, out of the belief that gender differences are not relevant to most matters of public occupation and discourse, or even social ones. In a community founded on "adams," there is no concern for tension, embarrassment or special excitement, nor for deterioration into levity and sexuality — in its atmosphere there is no sensitivity at all to the difference between male and female, and it remains a dry factual matter with no influence at all on the mood or the character of the encounter. Except that, in reality, one cannot make this sharp and simple division between "the adam of chapter 1" and "the adam of chapter 2" — every person is made up of both

these facets together. The analysis is theoretical; in practice, everyone necessarily brings with them into the social field the baggage of chapter 2 as well, including sexuality, attraction and the deep longing for romance and marital intimacy. For this we require the virtue of modesty.

The Transparent Wall

Modesty means that a person surrounds himself with a kind of transparent wall, which separates between the social, general-"human" domain, open to sharing, and the personal-intimate domain. This wall is not alienation, nor is it shame or fear, but rather precisely the capacity to present a warm countenance while still covering and preserving one's selfhood and self-respect, revelation and appearance through clothing. Just as "it is the glory of God to conceal a matter,"[10] so too the honor of the soul and the body (of which, too, it is said that it is made in the image of God[11]). Not everything is to be exposed — exposure is a violation of holiness, of distinctiveness, of the sublime, of spirituality — "a trustworthy spirit conceals a matter." [12]

This is a virtue required as part of a person's character and his relation to himself, and it is applied mainly within society. Even within a separate men's or women's society, the approach and psychic attitude ought to be such that not everything is placed on the surface, not every matter belongs in the public domain. Thus, for instance, one need not converse about very physical matters, such as the experience of sexuality or bodily needs.[13] In mixed society the boundary is wider — not to expose oneself too much, not to arrive at a state of unrestraint and levity. Deep, delicate personal exposure should be reserved for situations of intimacy, which, in its fullest sense, finds expression only within coupledness.

As stated, it would be wrong to pretend that our mixed society is "sterile" of psychic content connected to "the adam of chapter 2"; the proper way to relate to this content is through "conscious repression," treating it as a "hidden presence," concealed. That is, not a denial of the existence of romantic feelings and longings, and not a childish shame of them, but their mature acceptance, together with a tacit agreement to leave them aside, kept private, in the private domain, and to make an effort to guard against bringing them up into the social domain — not only in deed or in speech but even through psychic orientation toward these domains in the mixed situation. This is a mature consciousness, one that recognizes that every individual arrives dressed at the public-social "arena."

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Notes

1. Mainly if we place our perspective on the positions within the national-religious Torah world (and set aside, to some degree, the world of Haredi Torah). It is striking that the extreme positions (near-total separation or near-total mixing) are minority positions.

2. If I take, for example, the debate that plays out in the youth movements, I feel that the subject of personal improvement in modesty is often neglected by both sides of the debate — those who support separation as the ideal may feel that, once they have indeed built such a society, they have

thereby cultivated the virtue of modesty for themselves, while those who oppose separation may feel that, in doing so, they have exempted themselves from the burden of modesty.

3. In certain respects, the concept of modesty is mainly relevant in a mixed society or situation. This is especially true in light of my definition of the concept of inter-sexual modesty — modesty is the correct way of relating to members of the opposite sex. In a state where there are only men or only women, there is no room to speak of a correct relation toward those who are not present, and so the subject arises less to begin with.

4. It is a great question why so considerable a portion of the discussions, polemics and public halakhic rulings deal with youth society and the question of the youth movements, rather than with adult society. This state of affairs seems to me problematic in principle, whatever its causes. For youth society and adult society raise different questions, and although there is a broad basis of overlap in the spiritual and character-related principles that should guide proper conduct in both societies, the questions of adult society ought to be granted broader consideration and attention. Some of the arguments and considerations that take part in the discussion of the mixed or separate youth movement are not relevant to the modesty called for in adult society (such as tactical-educational considerations, attention to the distinctive ferment of adolescence, or attention to the fact that youth constitute a society of singles who have no other setting in which to give expression to their romantic and sexual sides), and the discussion frequently mixes considerations of essence with considerations of tact and timing, so that essential modesty emerges less clearly clarified.

5. In the essay I will formulate things from the son's point of view, for convenience, but generally the situation is symmetric and holds equally in the opposite direction.

6. These words are based on the words of Rav Shagar, "Modesty and Shame," in *Katonot Or*, p. 117: "Modesty is prone, not infrequently, to turn into a disguise and an alienation, into an opaque and rigid mask that creates a barrier between us and the other, and even into a person's inability to attain intimacy with his own body. Shame, for its part, can deteriorate and turn into a childish, immature and infantile consciousness that is unable to accept itself with any breadth, and which, when it encounters itself, becomes entangled and wishes to evaporate and become 'nothing'... Does the Jew indeed flee from his body?" Rav Shagar deals mainly with a person's relation to his own body, but the matters are connected, since in my discomfort with sexual otherness I am, in effect, apprehensive of the disclosure of what the difference of sex does to me, of its intimate influence on my emotional state.

7. One could object and say that my claim is not really a claim, since it could be raised against any halakhic norm connected to modesty. If we assume, for example, that the modern factual norm is that a woman's exposed shoulder no longer arouses any man, one could argue against halakha that by forbidding the exposure of the shoulder it loads it with an unnecessary and unnatural sexual charge. From here one could arrive at total halakhic anarchism, since the licentious norm would be the one dictating halakha, rather than the reverse. Indeed, there is a certain paradox here that must be balanced — on the one hand, halakhic language purports to represent "healthy reality," the "natural" threshold of arousal of the ideal modest norms; and on the other hand, that same language itself also generates the psychic and conscious norms of actual reality. My answer, therefore, is that the halakhic language should be kept at its formal minimum (or close to it), and that any stringency beyond it should be adapted to place and time. In other words, there is certainly a difference between halakhic guidance that has already been written and sealed as binding halakha, and new guidance derived solely from a general spirit or from "the view of the Torah." Only regarding the latter would it be legitimate to argue that their harm outweighs their benefit.

8. See Avot 3:13.

9. One could argue that, in effect, I have accepted the claim that there is an essential and ineliminable sexual tension in every mixed society, except that I have sublimated the concept of "sexual tension." Instead of speaking of sexual attraction, I spoke of romantic attraction, but in fact this is a transformation and refinement of the very same thing. This claim is correct to the same degree that one accepts the general claim of sublimation, according to which the experience of love itself, as we are accustomed to relate to it in our culture, is a refinement and softening of the sexual drive. We generally tend to reject psychological and evolutionary claims of this kind, since we see in them a reductionist stance — that is, claims that come to "lower" the grandeur and spirituality of high human experiences (love, for example) and to place their entire existence and meaning on the low, coarse physical plane. But the idea of sublimation can be accepted in full without taking it in the reductionist-materialist direction. The dualistic approach, which posits both matter-body and spirit-soul as really existing, speaks of a constant correspondence and correlation between these two ontological planes, like two sides of a mirror; what happens here happens there too, and what happens there happens here in parallel as well, and there is no need to enter into resolving the question of causality in order to hold the position that both planes have real existence worthy of consideration, and to use the language that this position requires. Romantic love exists for us as a real concept with an independent existence, separate from the concepts of sex and physical attraction, and this distinction matters to us and bears fruit in the existential and practical sphere. As regards this essay, even if one takes the concept of romantic love and attraction as nothing but a sublimation of the sexual drive — a conception I find difficult to accept — there is still essential importance in language that locates the lack of modesty on the emotional-romantic plane rather than on the physical-sexual plane.

10. Proverbs 25:2.

11. See, for example, Vayikra Rabbah (Vilna), Parashah 34:3: "'The merciful man does good to his own soul' (Prov. 11:17) — this refers to Hillel the Elder, who, when taking leave of his students, would walk along with them. His students said to him: Master, where are you going? He said to them: To perform a mitzvah. They said to him: And what mitzvah is this? He said to them: To bathe in the bathhouse. They said to him: And is this a mitzvah? He said to them: Yes! If the statues of kings, which are set up in theaters and circuses, have someone appointed over them to scour and wash them, and he is provided with sustenance for this, and moreover is raised up among the nobility of the kingdom — then I, who was created in the image and likeness, as it is written (Gen. 9), 'for in the image of God He made man' — how much more so!"

12. Proverbs 11:13.

13. On the Talmudic statement that "had the Torah not been given, we would have learned modesty from the cat," Rashi comments: "for it does not relieve itself in the presence of a person, and covers its excrement" (Eruvin 100b).